



"AS A CHILD, ONE IS VULNERABLE TO THE DARKER WORLD, SO INSTINCTIVELY YOU ROOT FOR THEM. BUT WHEN THE CHILD IS EVIL, IT JUST COMES AS A SHOCK"

ANANYA BANERJEE,
Writer and co-director of Adhura



ImMature
Amazon Prime Video
Season three of this coming-of-age romantic comedy series, another TVF property, continues its exploration of adolescent love

a broken home and losing a parent can affect them. Purohit believes that shows like *Adhura* "will prompt even adult viewers to reflect and empathise" with challenges the young face.

In fact, a part of the appeal of such shows among the older demographic is the sense of nostalgia they evoke, along with a need to stay abreast with popular culture. It explains why Netflix's *Stranger Things* (2016—), whose central characters are all kids contending with supernatural beings, continues to be a phenomenon in itself.

It's this mass appeal that drives Tanya Bami, series head of Netflix India, to develop more titles in the young-adults genre, in addition to the fact that "it allows for new voices to come forth with fresh ideas". In addition, says Bami, "it lends to exciting subjects that are current, poignant or have the potential to become cultural moments due to their resonance".

Nothing demonstrated that better than *Class*. The series initiated a much-needed sociocultural conversation by exposing the class divide at urban Indian schools. "The opportunity to address this subject through the lens of the youth who have the power to mirror society as well as hold a mirror to it was a huge differentiator," says Bami about the show, which has been greenlit for another season.

Given the increasing success of the genre, it's no surprise that whole new shows—or new seasons of existing ones—are in the offing. Alongside *Class*, Netflix's pipeline includes new seasons of *Mismatched* (2020—), which talks about young ambitions, sexuality, romance and gaming and is set in a tech institute, and *Kota Factory* (2019—), which tracks the lives of IIT aspirants in Rajasthan's coaching capital. But by far, Netflix's most anticipated title in the genre is *The Archies*, a Zoya Akhtar-helmed musical adaptation of the beloved comic title, which explores friendship, freedom, love, heartbreak and rebellion in the fictional town of Riverdale. Later this year, TVF will drop another round of *ImMature* (2019—), a show set in a convent school, and *FLAMES* (2018—), which is about a budding romance at a tuition centre.

However, writing about and for the youth comes with its own challenges. Pandey feels that though there has always been a "demand" for the YA genre, India has a dearth of content compared to the US, where such shows abound. He attributes this to two factors. "The age group of the creators impacts a lot of content experiences you see. It's like how a young politician is 45, a young writer in the late 20s," he says. Then, there's the need to exercise care in terms of both content and culture when it comes to working with children. "I feel there are a lot of restrictions and inhibitions in how you'd actually be showing young adults," says Pandey. "Regulations and self-censorship make it tough to do youth-oriented stories. You have to be careful *ki galat impression toh nahin padh raha hai* [that shows are not having a bad influence]."

The lack of young blood in the writers' room translates into a deeper problem. It's not easy writing about Generation Alpha. "I feel their problems are different. They are much more individualistic," says Pandey. "Because of the internet, a 15-year-old in India is thinking almost like a 15-year-old in America. They are more global citizens. Being real is the only way to appeal to the generation." At TVF, to get a sense of the youth today, content research plays a pivotal role. It entails interviewing students in Tier-II and III towns to understand what they look forward to and the issues they face.

For *Adhura*'s makers, it meant understanding the very real fallout of bullying. They conducted workshops to gauge the children's feelings. Signs were designed for them to use if they sensed danger or discomfort while shooting intense scenes. Child acting coach Varadh Bhatnagar was present on the set throughout. In compliance with the guidelines laid down by the National Commission for Protection of Child Rights, shooting with child actors was restricted to eight hours, with a guardian accompanying them.

Despite it all, filmmakers in India today, far from being apprehensive, are trying to not only embrace the genre but also expand it. "Kids today are so woke and bright and have such a wonderful worldview," says Banerjee. And if that can be brought to the screen astutely, Indian filmmaking will only be the better for it. ■